

Bible Study (Faith)

QOTD: What area of your life can you be trusting God more?

What is Faith?

- Faith defined biblically is found in Hebrews 11:1 → “The substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen”
- What does this mean? → For me, I first didn’t quite know fully
- Just as our physical eyesight is the sense that gives us evidence of the physical world, **faith** is the “sense” that gives us evidence of the invisible, spiritual world.
- The Bible doesn’t recommend a “blind leap” of faith → Acts 17:11
- The "assurance" and "conviction" of faith is acting in full confidence that God would do as He had promised → it is based in the very reliability of God’s promises!
- Godly faith is true trust... and true trust leads to obedience
- All the examples of people in this chapter lived well before Jesus, but still looked ahead to His coming and had FAITH! → faith leads to obedience even when the outcome wasn’t clear (e.g., Abraham in Hebrews 11:8)
- Faith is not true in fear → 1 John 4:18
- Faith causes you to run to something, fear causes you to run from something

Faith in What? Faith in Who?

- You may hear from people “well, my faith works for me”
- No... your faith needs to work for God and be sufficient in death
- We all have fallen short and all stand guilty before God → Ephesians 2:3 and Romans 3:22a
- The object of your faith is more important than how much faith you have (thin/thick ice analogy)
- Our faith must be solely in Jesus and we must have our own faith
- You cannot rely on the faith of your parents, grandparents, friends, etc... AND you cannot have faith IN yourself or others
- Saving faith comes from hearing the gospel, or Good News → Romans 10:17
- However, what we do is the result of what we truly believe. Simply claiming to have faith in Christ is meaningless; saving faith is a faith which results in action → James 2:17
- True "vegetarians" don't eat hamburgers → likewise people who truly have faith don't make a habit of ignoring the teachings of Jesus (obviously still far from perfect)
- Also not about “doing things” → Matthew 7:21-23
- “What’s the difference between believing in God and believing God?”

Why Faith in Jesus?

- How can one man suffering for a few hours on a cross be sufficient for the sins of all?
- It is because of who He is!! → fully God + fully man, weighing scale analogy
- The entirety of the faith is weighed in Jesus being raised from the dead... if He did not, then our faith is in vain/useless → 1 Corinthians 15:14
- However, that is not the case
- Earlier in the chapter, Paul speaks about the resurrection → 1 Corinthians 15:4-6
- It would be crazy if I died and came back to life... that is what God wants to do with us spiritually!
- Faith in Jesus is not dead, but alive! → 1 Peter 1:3
- Faith is Jesus seals us with the Holy Spirit → 2 Corinthians 1:21-22
- The presence of the Holy Spirit, which we receive via faith, is what makes us holy... NOT our own actions or what we do for God
- On our best day, we still don't compare to God's goodness → Isaiah 64:6
- "Where has God proven Himself faithful in your past?"

Strengthening and Applying Your Faith

- Saving faith comes from hearing the gospel, or Good News → Romans 10:17
- How can this faith be developed?
- Read your Bible! Faith grows as we spend time in Scripture and learn who God is → if you're looking for a word from God, read the word of God
- When you face doubt, remind yourself of who God is by recalling Scripture
- Faith grows in community → no such thing as a solo Christian (Hebrews 10:25)
- Faith doesn't just grow in comfort... it grows when it's tested
- God often stretches our faith by placing us in situations we can't control
- Control comes from fear... you must let go of control to trust God
- Trials teach us that His strength is enough → 2 Corinthians 12:9 and Romans 5:3-5
- Suffering refines your faith and builds endurance → Romans 5:3-5 and 1 Peter 1:7
- Faith clings to God's presence, not explanations → sometimes we don't get answers in our suffering, but we do get God's presence!
- Real faith leads you to trust God *is near* even when life feels dark
- Do I seek comfort more in God's presence or in understanding my situation?

Continued

- Always important to tie our faith back to the cross... not in ourselves, not in other people, not in other things, not what we do → none of these can save us from death
- Developing faith is definitely not easy, but Jesus is the example
- Jesus suffered deeply, but trusted the Father through it
- Faith looks beyond the pain of anything we go through to the promise of resurrection
- Hebrews 12:2
- “What would it look like to show your faith through actions at school, work, or with friends?”
- Who in your life helps your faith grow, and who might you encourage in theirs?